

Records Request — Curtis Babcock
Jacksonville State Hospital for the Insane, admission 26 January 1858

Who I am and why I'm calling

My name is Robert Babcock. I am a documented great-great-great-grandson of Curtis Babcock (b. about 1822, Scott, Cortland County, New York; d. 1870, believed Galva, Henry County, Illinois), through the following unbroken, sourced line:

Curtis Babcock → his son **James Anson Babcock** (1849–1932) → his son **Arthur Rueben Babcock** (1875–1922) → his son **Rawleigh Oliver Babcock** → **Stanley Babcock** → myself.

[Robert — confirm/adjust the exact number of generations between Stanley and yourself before sending or reading this aloud; I did not have that detail.]

I am researching my family history and trying to document what became of Curtis Babcock after a documented 1858 mental-health crisis. I am not seeking anything about a living person — every individual named below has been deceased for well over a century.

What I already know, and how I know it

I have three pieces of documentation already in hand, which I believe point to a specific case file in your holdings:

- Two contemporary newspaper notices from the Freeport Journal (Freeport, Stephenson County, Illinois):
 - January 7, 1858, page 3 — reports that the Stephenson County Board of Supervisors appointed a committee (Dr. Mattis, Jas. Millikan, and F. Baker) “to take charge of Curtis Babcock, the insane man now confined in the County Jail.”
 - January 14, 1858, page 2 — a formal Board resolution referring “the case of Curtis Babcock, now confined in the County Jail as an insane pauper,” to the same committee, and authorizing payment of the jailer’s (Wm. W. Smith) bill for his custody.
- The Jacksonville State Hospital’s own admission ledger (as transcribed by researcher Shirley Aleguas from the original hospital record book, and archived online) lists:

“Babcock, Curtiss | Age 36 | NY | Admitted 26 Jan 1858 | Discharged 21 Jul 1858 | Co. of Res.: Stephenson | Nearest Kin/Guardian/Notes: ‘Brother of Mrs. Davis of that county.’”

Based on the admission age of 36 in January 1858, Curtis was born about 1821–1822 — consistent with his known birth window. He was discharged alive after roughly six months and is not on the hospital’s separate list of patients who died in custody, which matches his reappearance, alone, in the July 1865 Illinois State Census at Oneco, Stephenson County.

What I am hoping to find

The admission ledger entry is only a summary line. I understand from published research on this hospital (a 2019 peer-reviewed history, Howarth & Aleguas, “Through a glass darkly,” *History of Psychiatry*) that a more detailed intake record exists in a separate series, and that this series specifically captured parent and family-background information at the time of admission. I am hoping to obtain whatever survives for this specific case, particularly

anything naming Curtis Babcock's parents, siblings, or place of origin in New York — which would resolve an open question in my family research about his father's identity.

The series I believe may hold this, based on the Illinois State Archives' own published finding aids, are:

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Questions to ask on the phone

- “I have a specific admission date — January 26, 1858, discharged July 21, 1858, patient Curtis Babcock (also spelled ‘Curtiss’), county of residence Stephenson. Does Record Series 252.003 (Commitment Papers) or 252.004 (Register of Patients) still survive for that date, and how would I request a copy?”
- “What is your process for a family member requesting historical mental-health records this old — is a notarized statement of descent enough, or is a court order genuinely required, as one published study on this hospital suggested?”
- “Is there a research-request form, and is there a fee for a search or for copies?”
- “If this specific record no longer survives, is there any other surviving intake or committee paperwork for a Stephenson County case from January 1858?”

Contact

Illinois State Archives — Margaret Cross Norton Building, Springfield, IL 62756

Phone: (217) 782-2647

(Note: county-level original records for this era are also held at the Illinois Regional Archives Depository at Northern Illinois University, DeKalb — (815) 753-1807 — which holds Stephenson County's surviving Probate Claim Dockets, 1848–1859, in case the State Archives directs you there instead.)

Full source citations, for reference

- Freeport Journal (Freeport, IL), January 7, 1858, p. 3, “Curtis Babcock.”
- Freeport Journal (Freeport, IL), January 14, 1858, p. 2, county board resolution.
- Directory of Jacksonville State Hospital Patients, 1854–1870, transcribed by Shirley Aleguas, archived at: https://web.archive.org/web/20241006040255/http://sites.rootsweb.com/~ilmaga/morgan2/statehosp/mcsh_adm-b.html
- Howarth, R. & Aleguas, S., “Through a glass darkly: the Illinois State Hospital for the Insane at Jacksonville,” History of Psychiatry (2019) — https://discovery.ucl.ac.uk/id/eprint/10095783/3/Howarth_Final_text_version_for_UCL.pdf
- Illinois State Archives finding aid, Record Series 252.003 (“Commitment Papers”) — <https://researchworks.oclc.org/archivegrid/collection/data/36677610>

- Illinois State Archives finding aid, Record Series 252.004 (“Register of Patients”) and related Record Group 252 case records — <https://researchworks.oclc.org/archivegrid/archiveComponent/36677709>
- 1865 Illinois State Census, Oneco, Stephenson County (Curtis Babcock, alone in household).